

Skill Development Self-Assessment

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In this course, there have been many counseling skills I have been able to learn and implement during role-play. There have also been skills I look forward to keep strengthening and be able to implement them accurately and appropriately in the correct context. During my counseling tape script role-play, I was able to look back and reflect on the skills I used, areas I could potentially strengthen and grow on, how I plan to retain and improve these skills, some patterns I noticed and how this role play affected me and personal issues that surfaced during the session. Lastly, I was also able to reflect on how I felt during supervision and what I took away. Reflecting upon what I have learned and can improve upon will help me accurately implement feedback on future sessions and at the same time help my future client achieve their goals. It is essential to reflect and acknowledge my role-playing counseling skills as a future counselor because it will help me flourish into the counselor I aspire to become soon.

Implementing skills can be a bit hard because I have had to listen to understand rather than listening to respond. I have been able to implement asking open ended questions that allows clients to express their concerns, their expressions, and feelings. Implementing these skills is helpful because I can better assess their challenges and acknowledge what the client might need help working on whether it is communication skills, coping strategies, or other challenges that can affect their day-to-day life. The second skill I implemented during the session was paraphrasing because it allowed me to recap what the client had said and discover whether I have gathered their feelings and experience as accurately as possible. It is important to paraphrase as the client can either tell whether we are going in the right direction or completely off from what they were saying. Another skill I was able to identify was door openers - this was used when I wanted to further explore the conversation I was having with the client and learn more about the

topic. The way I implemented door openers was by starting off my statement as “tell me more...” to give my client the freedom to go more into detail during the session. In addition to door openers, I also learned that using minimal encouragers such as “I see, right, mhm” to let the client know I am actively listening and following along so they feel encouraged to determine where the direction of the conversation goes. Lastly, I must acknowledge that although I practiced implementing the skill of reflection of feelings, it was nerve-wracking because I did not want to potentially be wrong about the client's feelings. More than not, I was scared that I would incorrectly project my feelings onto their experience. This is an area of weakness I plan on strengthening and growing from.

Improving these skills is challenging because we cannot grow them overnight and it will take trial-and-error to develop these skills. I had the most difficulty being able to reflect feelings during the session as I explained previously because I feared being “wrong”. I have recently learned that it is better to be wrong than to not acknowledge the client's feelings at all. The reason behind that is because it provides the client with reassurance that I am actively listening and trying to follow along. Another difficulty I faced during role-play was being comfortable with silence. I have never been comfortable with silence because I find it awkward and uncomfortable. Nonetheless, at times it is important to sit with one's own thoughts and feelings to be able to process our emotions during the session. I plan on improving these skills by continuing implementing them during role-play or at times practicing with family and friends during regular conversations. These skills will develop overtime, but I am hopeful that I will eventually get to a point where I will confidently reflect the client's feelings whether I am right or wrong in addition to being comfortable with silence. During the session, I also became aware that at times my own feelings about the client's situation wanted to overtake the session and

express my own opinions. I noticed it because I was able to make any damaging comments into our session and the rapport, we had built but it is something I plan on being careful about.

My thoughts regarding supervision are that it is very helpful. I learned a lot during the supervision and watching the 30-minute role-play tapescript together. We went over a few concerns I had on my tone of voice, the way I was using minimal encouragers, a few sentences that might've been seen as judgmental to the client and another stance where I used the word, "but" it felt like I dismissed the clients experiences by adding "but" that can be as bad as using an "at least" during counseling. I appreciated the experience, and the way feedback was given without feeling judged when I did something that could be improved upon. I will be taking away the fact I can use minimal encouragers the way I had previously been using them. I thought I was over-using them but during the supervision meeting, we concluded that it is good to use minimal encouragers, I was using them appropriately and pacing myself during the conversation while also using those encouragers such as "mhm, right, and I see".

In future sessions, I will be planning to implement the feedback I was given to develop my skills more efficiently but also have professional development in the area. Asking a few more open questions can help the client go more into detail during the session, reflecting on feelings is always important and it is okay to be wrong rather than completely ignoring what the client might be feeling. After supervision, I was able to further reflect what I can work on and how I can keep on developing skills to make a great counselor. Learning how to accept feedback is essential in my career because it will help me continue to grow and learn from my mistakes. I know that there is no such thing as a perfect counselor, but I do strive to be the best help I can to my future clients and provide the safe space they are looking for. Overall, I was able to fully reflect on what my weaknesses and my strengths are.